Show your evidence.

> **Public education has the same four problems in almost every country: access, learning, teachers and money. This dossier gives you the numbers, the countries and the sentences to talk about them.**

Name _____ **Date** _____

This is your page for the lesson. The numbers and titles match the lesson on the screen, so you can follow along. Write here, circle here. The answers are in the lesson, not on this page.

Bold on grey is a chunk to learn. Dotted is a word to look up.

1 WARM UP

Where do you stand?

Before you read anything, circle the answer closest to your opinion. There is no right answer.

Money is the main problem in public schools.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

Good teachers matter more than good buildings.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

A country can copy another country's school system.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

Brazilian students learn less than students in most other countries.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

How close is your guess?

Two numbers from the dossier. Write your guess.

Out of every 100 ten-year-olds in low- and middle-income countries, how many cannot read and understand a simple text?
Think about the whole group of countries, not only one.
My guess _____ %

What percentage of Brazilian 15-year-olds reached the basic level (level 2) in math in PISA 2022?
The test is the same in every country.
My guess _____ %

Talk about these first

Then read the article and see who agrees with you.

1 **Think of a public school you know well. What worked? What did not?**

2 **Which is the biggest problem in public education today: access, learning, teachers or money? Why?**

3 **Could a school system from another country work here? Which one, and why?**

4 **A friend says public schools are a disaster. What do you say? What do you not say?**

5 **Should a government spend more on education, or spend better? Can it do both?**

2 ARTICLE

SOCIETY · EDUCATION

Public schools, four problems

273 million children and young people are out of school. Many of those who are in school are not learning to read.

By **EIC Magazine** · 5 min read

Every country says it believes in public education. Then the numbers arrive. In 2026, UNESCO reported that 273 million children and young people were out of school, the seventh yearly rise in a row. About one in six school-age children is excluded from education. **According to UNESCO**, the causes include armed conflict, population growth and shrinking education budgets.

ACCESS

In Afghanistan, the problem is easy to see. Since the Taliban returned to power, around 2.2 million girls have been barred from secondary school. UNICEF and UNESCO say it is the only country where girls and women are completely barred from secondary and higher education.

Globally, **the hardest hit are** children in sub-Saharan Africa and in conflict zones. UNESCO also says that official statistics probably underestimate the problem.

LEARNING

Being in school is not the same as learning. In 2022, the World Bank, UNICEF and UNESCO estimated that 7 in 10 ten-year-olds in low- and middle-income countries could not read and understand a simple text. This is called learning poverty. Before the pandemic, the figure was 57%.

Brazil shows a quieter version of the problem. In PISA 2022, Brazilian 15-year-olds scored 379 in math, **compared with** an OECD average of 472. Only 27% reached the basic level, against about 70% across the OECD. The scores were almost the same as in 2018.

TEACHERS

Behind every classroom is a teacher, and the world is running short of them. UNESCO projects a deficit of 44 million primary and secondary teachers by 2030. New data also show that primary teachers earn slightly less than other professionals with similar qualifications.

Respect is part of the problem. In the OECD's TALIS 2024 survey, only about a third of teachers agreed that teachers are valued in society. The gap between countries is huge: more than 70% in Viet Nam and Uzbekistan, less than 10% in France and Portugal. In Brazil, 47% of teachers said verbal abuse or intimidation was a source of stress, against an average of 18%.

MONEY

Money is part of the answer. In 2026, Brazil's national pay floor for public school teachers rose by 5.4%, to R$ 5,130.63 a month for a 40-hour week. States and municipalities pay it with Fundeb, the national school fund, with help from the federal government.

MONEY OR TRUST?

Supporters of more funding say the numbers are clear: a country cannot fix what it does not pay for. Others look at Finland. To teach in a Finnish basic or secondary school, you need a master's degree. The country has no classroom inspectors, and principals guide teachers through trust rather than control.

A third group says every country starts from a different place. A system that works in Finland may not travel to Afghanistan, or to a small town in Brazil. UNESCO's 2026 report says that no single policy can solve exclusion. It calls for tailored approaches and sustained investment.

So the question for every school system is the same: which of the four problems comes first?

> **"Every learner deserves a teacher who is well prepared, well supported and empowered to thrive in the profession."**
>
> UNESCO, ILO, UNICEF and Education International, World Teachers' Day 2026

273 million
children and young people out of school (UNESCO, 2026)

7 in 10
ten-year-olds in low- and middle-income countries cannot read a simple text (2022)

44 million
primary and secondary teachers missing by 2030 (UNESCO)

2.2 million
Afghan girls barred from secondary school (UNICEF and UNESCO, 2026)

Sources: UNESCO, Global Education Monitoring Report (2026); World Bank, UNICEF, UNESCO and others, The State of Global Learning Poverty (2022); OECD, PISA 2022 results; UNESCO, Global Report on Teachers; OECD, TALIS 2024, as reported by Education International and Gazeta do Povo; UNICEF and UNESCO on Afghanistan (2025 and 2026); World Bank on Finland (2018); Agência Senado (January 2026).

Comments

7 readers · fictional voices for this lesson

Marina R. · Santos · primary teacher
I love my students, but too many of them reach fourth grade without reading well. We move on to the next unit because the calendar says so.

Paulo S. · Campinas · secondary teacher
Money is the whole problem. Everything else is a distraction. Pay teachers properly and the rest will follow.

Dona Cida · Curitiba · retired teacher
Finland sounds like a dream. They trust their teachers. Here, everyone has an opinion about teaching, and nobody asks the teachers.

Rafael · São Paulo · parent
As a parent, I don't care about Finland. I care if my daughter's teacher shows up and if she learns to read this year.

Helena · Londrina · school coordinator
We can't copy Finland, but we can borrow one habit: ask teachers before we decide. We started a monthly meeting last year.

Diego · Recife · secondary teacher
Afghanistan makes me ashamed to complain. Our problems are real, but those girls can't even go to class.

Clara · Lisbon · teacher trainer
Portugal is on the list of countries where fewer than one teacher in ten feels valued. We have good training, and teachers still leave. Respect matters as much as money.

Words from the article

a distraction
uma distração

a source of stress
uma fonte de estresse

according to
de acordo com (nunca "according with")

armed conflict
conflito armado

barred
proibido de, impedido de

basic level
nível básico (de proficiência)

borrow
tomar emprestado, adotar

compared with
em comparação com

conflict zones
zonas de conflito

deficit
déficit

excluded
excluído

inspectors
fiscais, inspetores

learning poverty
pobreza de aprendizagem

low- and middle-income countries
países de renda baixa e média

master's degree
mestrado

move on
seguir adiante, passar para o próximo

OECD average
média da OCDE

on the list
na lista

out of school
fora da escola

pay floor
piso salarial

population growth
crescimento populacional

run short of
estar ficando sem, faltar

school-age children
crianças em idade escolar

secondary school
ensino fundamental II e médio

shrinking
em queda, encolhendo

similar qualifications
qualificações semelhantes

sustained investment
investimento contínuo

tailored approaches
soluções sob medida

the hardest hit are
os mais atingidos são

valued
valorizado

verbal abuse
agressão verbal

More words from the exercises

a broken system
um sistema falido

according to UNESCO
segundo a UNESCO

attrition
evasão, saída gradual de profissionais

burnt out
esgotado (burnout)

class size
tamanho da turma

close the gap
reduzir a diferença

compare apples with oranges
comparar alhos com bugalhos

could you share the source
você poderia compartilhar a fonte

fair point
boa colocação

falling through the cracks
ficar sem apoio, passar despercebido

I hear you
entendo o que você diz

I see your point, but
entendo seu ponto, mas

it would take
isso exigiria

money matters, but
dinheiro importa, mas

one option would be
uma opção seria

one problem keeps coming up
um problema continua aparecendo

out of control
fora de controle

per-pupil spending
gasto por aluno

teacher shortage
falta de professores

teaching to the test
ensinar só para a prova

that may be true in some countries
isso pode ser verdade em alguns países

throwing money at the problem
jogar dinheiro no problema

what does the evidence say
o que as evidências dizem

3 CHECK

What does the article say?

Facts first, then voices. Every answer is in the text or in the comments.

True or false?

Read the sentence. Is it true, according to the article? If it is false, write the correct fact in the line.

EXAMPLE "UNESCO says progress in keeping children in school has slowed in almost every region."

True

It is true. UNESCO's 2026 report says progress has slowed across almost every region.

1 "In 2022, 7 in 10 ten-year-olds in low- and middle-income countries could read a simple text."

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact:

2 "Afghanistan is the only country where girls and women are completely barred from secondary and higher education."

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact:

3 "UNESCO projects a deficit of 44 million primary and secondary teachers by 2030."

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact:

4 "In PISA 2022, Brazil scored higher than the OECD average in math."

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact:

5 "Finland uses classroom inspectors to check every teacher."

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact:

6 "About a third of teachers agree that teachers are valued in society."

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact:

Find the reader

All the answers are in the comments. Read them again and circle the name.

EXAMPLE Who says money is the whole problem?

Paulo

Paulo says everything else is a distraction. Pay teachers properly and the rest will follow.

1 Who says an ordinary parent does not care about Finland?

◯ Marina ◯ Rafael ◯ Helena

2 Who suggests borrowing one habit, not the whole system?

◯ Helena ◯ Dona Cida ◯ Diego

3 Who says Portugal is on the list of countries where teachers feel little respect?

◯ Paulo ◯ Diego ◯ Clara

4 Who says nobody asks the teachers?

◯ Marina ◯ Dona Cida ◯ Clara

4 CHUNKS

Say it in chunks, not in words

People who talk about education repeat the same phrases. Learn the whole phrase, and the sentence builds itself.

Pick the chunk

Circle the words that complete the sentence. Each answer is a chunk, not a single word.

EXAMPLE Many families cannot pay for books and uniforms. This is a problem of _____ to school.

access

Access to school: the chance to attend. Access to is the chunk.

1 273 million children and young people are _____.

◯ out the school ◯ out of school ◯ off school

2 _____ UNESCO, progress has slowed in almost every region.

◯ According with ◯ Following to ◯ According to

3 Brazil scored 379 in math, _____ an OECD average of 472.

◯ compared with ◯ compared than ◯ comparing at

4 The world faces a teacher _____ of 44 million by 2030.

◯ shortness ◯ short ◯ shortage

5 Only 27% of students _____ the basic level in math.

◯ reached ◯ arrived ◯ went

6 _____ to train more teachers, but it would take sustained investment.

◯ One option will being ◯ One option would be ◯ One option is be

Write the missing word

Write the missing word or words in the space. All four are in the article.

EXAMPLE Many ten-year-olds cannot read a simple text. UNESCO calls this a learning **poverty**.

Learning poverty means a ten-year-old cannot read and understand a simple text.

1 Primary teachers are paid below other professionals with similar _____.

2 The gap between countries is huge: more than 70% in Viet Nam and Uzbekistan, _____ than 10% in France and Portugal.

3 Finland has no classroom inspectors. Principals guide teachers through _____ rather than control.

4 Behind every classroom is a teacher, and the world is running _____ them.

5 LISTEN

The sentence you will say tomorrow

Three short moments from a meeting. Listen, then choose.

What did you hear?

Your teacher will play each clip. Listen as many times as you like. Then circle the answer.

EXAMPLE ▶ What does the speaker say about the group?

It is very large

Listen for the last sentence.

1 What does the speaker say about teachers?

- ◯ They are paid too much
- ◯ They are not trained
- ◯ Society does not value them

2 What does she propose?

- ◯ One idea from Finland
- ◯ The whole Finnish system
- ◯ Closing teacher training

3 What is the speaker's conclusion?

- ◯ Brazil is above average
- ◯ Money alone will not fix it
- ◯ Math is not important

6 BOSS?

Can you say it at a meeting?

Read each sentence from the staff room. Circle the blue thumb if you can say it at a meeting. Circle the pink thumb if it is too much.

		I CAN SAY IT AT A MEETING	TOO MUCH
1	"Throwing money at the problem."		
2	"The kids are out of control."		
3	"Kids are falling through the cracks."		
4	"Schools are falling apart."		
5	"It's a broken system."		
6	"Teachers are burnt out."		
7	"We need to close the gap."		
8	"Parents don't care about school."		
9	"Teaching to the test."		

7 THE CASE

Make your case in five moves

Name the problem. Give one number, with its source. Say who is affected. Propose one measure.

1 NAME THE PROBLEM

One problem keeps coming up: too many children are out of school.

Start with the topic, not with the complaint.

2 GIVE ONE NUMBER, WITH ITS SOURCE

According to UNESCO, 273 million children and young people are out of school.

The source goes first. Then the number.

3 SAY WHO IS AFFECTED

The hardest hit are children in sub-Saharan Africa and in conflict zones.

A group of people, not a whole continent.

4	**COMPARE**	**In Brazil, 27% of 15-year-olds reached the basic level in math, compared with about 70% across the OECD.** Same test, same year, two groups.
5	**PROPOSE ONE MEASURE, AND SAY ITS LIMIT**	**One option would be to train more teachers, but it would take sustained investment.** A small proposal sounds more credible than a big promise.

Too blunt, say this

Write a better version on the line. Say it out loud first.

1 Public schools are a disaster.

2 Teachers are paid nothing.

3 Governments don’t care.

4 Kids today can’t even read.

5 Finland did it, so why can’t we?

YOUR TURN · THE CASE

Choose one problem from the article: access, learning, teachers or money. Make your case in five moves, out loud, in under one minute.

8 THE ANSWER

When someone disagrees

Do not argue. Agree with what you can, limit the claim, and ask for the evidence.

1	**AGREE FIRST**	**I see your point, but the numbers suggest something else.** Say what you accept before you say what you doubt.
2	**LIMIT THE CLAIM**	**That may be true in some countries. In others, the problem is access.** A claim about every country is almost always wrong.
3	**ASK FOR EVIDENCE**	**What does the evidence say about that?** A calm question works better than a counter-argument.
4	**COMPARE FAIRLY**	**Let’s not compare apples with oranges. Finland and Afghanistan start from very different places.** Same kind of country, same kind of data.
	ASK FOR THE SOURCE	**Could you share the source? I’d like to read it.**

5

The best answer to a number you do not trust.

A real exchange

TEACHER	Money is the whole problem. Fix the budget and schools will fix themselves.
COORDINATOR	**Money matters, but** Finland's teachers are trained to master's level and trusted to teach.
TEACHER	Finland is small and rich. Would that work in Brazil?
COORDINATOR	**Fair point**. I'd take one idea, not the whole system: more time for teacher training.

When a parent pushes back

PARENT	I don't care about Finland. I care if my daughter learns to read this year.
TEACHER	**I hear you**, and I want the same thing. Could I show you what she is reading now, and what we are doing to help her?

YOUR TURN · COORDINATOR

The coordinator says: "Public schools in other countries have the same problems. Why change anything here?" Answer in three moves: agree, limit the claim, propose.

YOUR TURN · COLLEAGUE

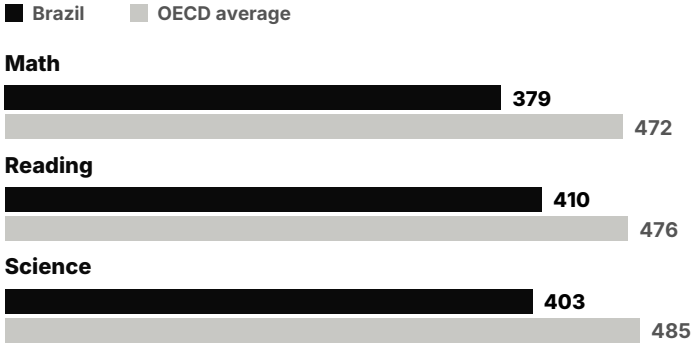
A colleague says: "Nothing works. Look at Afghanistan." Answer in three moves: agree, compare fairly, ask for evidence.

9 OTHER SIDE

How a policymaker reads it

A minister, a secretary of education or a school head does not look at one classroom. She looks at numbers, country by country. Here are the numbers and the words she uses.

Brazil and the OECD average



Mean scores. OECD, PISA 2022 results.

Numbers you can quote

273 million	children and young people are out of school, the seventh yearly rise in a row. UNESCO, Global Education Monitoring Report, 2026
44 million	primary and secondary teachers are missing worldwide, a deficit projected for 2030. UNESCO, Global Report on Teachers
7 in 10	ten-year-olds in low- and middle-income countries cannot read and understand a simple text. World Bank, UNICEF, UNESCO and others, 2022
2.2 million	Afghan girls are barred from secondary school. UNICEF and UNESCO, January 2026
47% vs 18%	of Brazilian teachers cite verbal abuse or intimidation as a source of stress, against the average of all participating countries. OECD, TALIS 2024, as reported by Education International and Gazeta do Povo
R$ 5,130.63	a month: the 2026 national pay floor for public school teachers in Brazil, for 40 hours a week. Agência Senado, 22 January 2026

Country files: one challenge, one fact

COUNTRY	CHALLENGE	THE FACT
Sub-Saharan Africa	**ACCESS**	Particularly affected by exclusion from school, together with conflict zones.
Afghanistan	**ACCESS**	2.2 million girls are barred from secondary school under the Taliban.
Brazil	**LEARNING**	27% of students at level 2 or above in math, PISA 2022. OECD: about 70%.
Brazil	**RESPECT**	47% of teachers stressed by verbal abuse. TALIS average: 18%.
Finland	**TEACHERS**	A master's degree to teach in basic and secondary school. No classroom inspectors.
Viet Nam, Uzbekistan	**STATUS**	More than 70% of teachers feel valued by society. TALIS average: about 35%.

Six terms and the sentence for the meeting

TERM	IN THE MEETING
out-of-school children *n.*	"273 million children and young people are out of school."
learning poverty *n.*	"Learning poverty means a 10-year-old cannot read and understand a simple text."
teacher shortage *n.*	"UNESCO projects a deficit of 44 million teachers by 2030."
teacher attrition *n.*	"How do we keep attrition from emptying our schools?"
class size *n.*	"Smaller class size helps only if we have enough teachers."
per-pupil spending *n.*	"What is our per-pupil spending compared with the national average?"

YOUR TURN · BUILD A FILE

Choose one country. Write a three-line file: the challenge, one fact with its source, and one measure.

10 NOW, AGAIN

Did the dossier move you?

Same four sentences. Circle your answer now. Look back at page 1. Did you move?

Money is the main problem in public schools.

Strongly disagree · Disagree · Not sure · Agree · Strongly agree

Good teachers matter more than good buildings.

Strongly disagree · Disagree · Not sure · Agree · Strongly agree

A country can copy another country's school system.

Strongly disagree · Disagree · Not sure · Agree · Strongly agree

Brazilian students learn less than students in most other countries.

Strongly disagree · Disagree · Not sure · Agree · Strongly agree

Facts come from UNESCO, UNICEF, the World Bank, the OECD (PISA 2022 and TALIS 2024), the Brazilian Senate and the World Bank's notes on Finland. The classroom phrases and sample answers are standard usage written for this lesson. The comments are fictional.